



**Global Business Week  
MBA for Executives  
Competitive Advantage in the Leisure Industries: Spain  
September 2026**

Faculty:

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Canvas site:

<https://canvas.upenn.edu/courses/1937089>

Start date:

Sunday, September 13, 2026, 5:30 pm

Barcelona, Spain

End:

Thursday, September 17, 2026, 8:30 pm

Madrid, Spain

Hotels:

Hotel Catalonia Boulevard (formerly the Gallery Hotel), Carrer del Rosselló, 249, Eixample, 08008 Barcelona, Spain, [+34 934 15 99 11](tel:+34934159911)

VP Plaza de España Design, Plaza de España, 5, Centro, 28008 Madrid, Spain, [+34 915 95 55 10](tel:+34915955510)

The leisure industries—travel, hospitality, sports, entertainment, media, gastronomy—account for one fifth of the economy of most countries in the world. This course offers the opportunity to learn about the competitive advantages that countries and companies have developed to become global players, illustrating it with the case of Spain, one of the most competitive leisure economies. The course consists of lectures, workshops, interactive case discussions, and company and government visits.

In order to facilitate learning, students will be asked to complete the following assignments.

Further details on the written assignments are available on the course Canvas site. **Please note, all assignments must be submitted by the deadline. Any late assignments will be penalized.**

- Pre-trip work (30% of grade):

- Attend the introductory session on August 24<sup>th</sup> from 8-9:30pm EST (zoom link will be provided; or watch the recording if you cannot attend) – 5%
- Complete Assignment 1: two reading responses – 10% (5% each)
- Complete Assignment 2: pre-trip reflection – 15%

**\* The deadline for submitting both pre-trip assignments is Sep 11 at 11:59pm EST**

- During trip (30% of grade):
  - Attendance and participation at scheduled sessions and events – 18%
  - Group Assignment: short reflection paper – 12%

**\* The deadline for submitting the Group Assignment is Sep 22 at 5:00 pm EST**

- Post-trip work (40% of grade):
  - Final Assignment: individual paper – 40%

**\* The deadline for submitting the Final Assignment is Oct 12 at 5:00 pm EST**

**Dress code:** No flip-flops, shorts, or t-shirts. Other than that, anything goes. Bring sensible shoes for walking/visiting vineyards etc. No need whatsoever for jackets, suits or ties.

### **Reading policy:**

- All readings listed on this syllabus are required and must be completed prior to the lectures or visits during the trip.
- Readings are available from our Canvas website under Course Materials @ Penn Libraries.

### **Attendance policy:**

- Attendance to all sessions is mandatory, including all scheduled meals and activities.
- Proper attendance means arriving on time, listening attentively, actively participating, and staying for the entire duration of the session. No phone use is permitted during guest speaker sessions.
- If you are unable to attend a session, or need to leave early, you must notify a member of the program staff (preferably in advance).
- Failure to adhere to these requirements will result in a grade penalty.

### **AI policy:**

- It is a violation of Wharton ethics rules to submit work that is entirely created either by someone else or by software such as AI tools. Plagiarism or other forms of cheating will be dealt with severely under relevant university procedures.
- Completing your assignments without using AI tools such as ChatGPT is preferred. However, if you feel that you need to, you may use AI tools to assist you for tasks such

as understanding concepts, brainstorming ideas, or final editing. AI can be a valuable means to facilitate your learning, but it should not be an alternative to learning. Be aware that AI tools are imperfect. They may be biased, inaccurate, or “hallucinate” false information. You are responsible for the content of your submissions, so review any AI-generated material carefully.

- If you do use AI tools to assist you with assignments in this course, you are expected to disclose that in your response and identify how you employed them. Where appropriate, you should identify prompts you used, and the relationship of what the AI created to what you eventually submitted. (This material does not count against any word limits.)

## About the Instructors

**Martine Haas** is the Vice Dean for Global Initiatives and the Dr. Felix Zandman Professor in International Management at the Wharton School. She received her Ph.D. in Organizational Behavior from Harvard University, an M.A. in International Relations from Yale University, and a B.A. in Human Sciences from Oxford University. Before joining the Wharton School in 2007, she served as a faculty member at Cornell University. In recent years, Professor Haas held the title of Lauder Chair Professor and served as the Anthony L. Davis Director of the Lauder Institute for Management and International Studies, and also as a member of the Presidential Commission for Countering Hate and Building Community at the University of Pennsylvania. Professor Haas’s research focuses on collaboration in global, knowledge-intensive organizations. She has published articles in leading academic and practitioner journals, and received awards for her research, service, and teaching. Prior to her academic career, she worked for McKinsey & Company in London and for the international aid agency Oxfam.

**Mireia Lizandra** has decades of professional and academic experience in sports management and law. Her career commenced at the United States Olympic Committee International Relations office, where she represented the organization at the 1991 Pan American Games in Cuba, the 1992 Winter Games in Albertville, and the 1992 Summer Games in her native Barcelona. She later served as the Program Director for the 197 National Olympic Committees at the 1996 Atlanta Games. Subsequently, she joined the Marquee Group, a sports marketing firm in New York. In 2007, she began working on the Madrid Olympic bids for 2012, 2016, and 2020 as part of the international team. Mireia's extensive teaching portfolio includes a three-year tenure at St. John’s University Law School and a professor for the International Sports Law Master LLM program at the University of Lleida, teaching in Spain, Colombia, Mexico, Chile, and Qatar. She is also a professor and tutor for the International Olympic Committee's MEMOS Executive Master program. Since 2011, she has been tutoring students in their Capstone projects for the Lauder Institute at the Wharton Business School and has collaborated with the Executive MBA program since 2014. She is also a tutor in the MESGO program from UEFA since 2022. Mireia holds a B.S. in Physical Education and a J.D. from the University of Barcelona. She earned her Master’s and Doctorate in Sports Administration from Temple University.

## List of Readings

*Please note: all Readings are on Canvas under Course Materials @ Penn Libraries*

- Barcelona. (2026, May 22). *Barcelona ranked third in the world for hosting congresses: Economic promotion: Barcelona City Council*. Economic Promotion.  
<https://www.barcelona.cat/promocioeconomica/en/news/news/barcelona-ranked-third-in-the-world-for-hosting-congresses-1637740>
- Bermúdez-González, G., Maldonado Canca, L. A., Cabrera-Sánchez, J. P., & Cobo-Paz, L. (2026). Symbols, sponsors and supporters: exploring the role of symbolic leadership and sponsorship congruence in fan behavior. *International Journal of Sports Marketing and Sponsorship*, 27(6), 36-63.
- Codinachs, L. (2026, May 4). *From Barcelona to the World: The Trends Redefining Mice*. The New Barcelona Post. <https://www.thenewbarcelonapost.com/en/from-barcelona-to-the-world-the-trends-redefining-mice/>
- Deloitte Sports Business Group. (2026). *Defending from the front: Annual review of football finance 2026*. Deloitte.
- Ferrer-Alos, L. (2020). Commercial Structures and the Globalisation of Viticulture in Catalonia: From Brandy to Wine and Cava (Eighteenth–Twentieth Centuries). *The Historical Review/La Revue Historique*, 17, 251-304.
- Hidalgo, A. (2024). Your room is ready: Tourism and urban revival. *Regional Science and Urban Economics*, 109, 104059.
- International Monetary Fund. European Dept. (2025). Spain: 2025 Article IV Consultation-Press Release; and Staff Report. *IMF Staff Country Reports*, 2025(121).
- Jerez, M. R. (2023). Tourism marketing of the Autonomous Communities of Spain to promote gastronomy as part of their destination branding. *International Journal of Gastronomy and Food Science*, 32, 100727.
- Juventeny Berdún, S. (2019). Much ‘more than a club’: Football Club Barcelona’s contribution to the rise of a national consciousness in Catalonia (2003–2014). *Soccer & Society*, 20(1), 103-122.
- Keen, C., Sanchez-Famoso, V., & Dana, L. P. (2024). Moderating effect of social capital on the dynamics between entrepreneurial orientation and internationalization of Spanish family owned businesses. *Journal of Management & Organization*, 30(1), 59-77.
- Marco-Lajara, B., Seva-Larrosa, P., Martínez-Falcó, J., & García-Lillo, F. (2022). Wine clusters and protected designations of origin (PDOs) in Spain: an exploratory analysis. *Journal of Wine Research*, 33(3), 146-167.
- MICE Tourism: Barcelona, destination for corporate events*. World Trade Center Barcelona. (2026, March 20). <https://wtcbarcelonaevents.com/en/blog/mice-tourism-barcelona/>
- Milano, C., Novelli, M., & Russo, A. P. (2024). Anti-tourism activism and the inconvenient truths about mass tourism, touristification and overtourism. *Tourism Geographies*, 26(8), 1313-1337.
- Viana-Lora, A., & Nel-lo-Andreu, M. (2023). Pathways for the social impact of research in Barcelona's tourism policy. *International Journal of Tourism Cities*, 9(2), 481-495.

### **Preliminary Schedule (subject to change)**

*Please note: this schedule will be updated on a daily basis. Check back regularly, including on Canvas, for the most current version.*

#### **Sunday, September 13<sup>th</sup>**

- 16:00 Hotel check-in available - *Catalonia Boulevard Hotel, Carrer del Rosselló, 249, Eixample, 08008 Barcelona, Spain*
- 17:00 Coffee available
- 17:30 Class Session 1 (at hotel) – Welcome by Professors Lizandra and Haas  
***Room:*** Level A, Crillon-Robert Room
- 18:30 Cocktail dinner at the Rooftop Event Bar (Partners are welcome to join)
- 21:00 End of dinner

#### **Monday, September 14<sup>th</sup>**

- 07:00 Restaurant is open for breakfast (included)
- 07:45 Meet in the lobby at 7:45 am sharp for the bus to MNAC (Museu Nacional d'Art de Catalunya)
- 08:30 Welcome Coffee at MNAC
- 09:00 Class Session 2 (at MNAC) - Presentation by Mario Rubert, Director of International Economic Promotion at Barcelona Activa (Part of Barcelona City Council)
- 10:15 Coffee break
- 10:30 Class Session 2 (cont.) - *Business Tourism: Travel versus MICE (Meetings, Incentives, Conferences, and Exhibitions)* by Maite Audet, Lecturer at the University of Barcelona
- 11:45 End of Presentations
- 12:00 Private tour of the MNAC (National Art Museum of Catalonia)
- 12:45 Group photo

- 13:00 Lunch in the museum
- 14:30 Walk (15-minute walk uphill) OR take the bus to INEF (School of Physical Education and Sports Sciences)
- 15:00 Class Session 3 (at INEF) - *Sporting Events as Drivers of MICE Industry - Formula 1 and Moto GP (Grand Prix)* by Isabel Juárez, Commercial Director at Circuit de Barcelona-Catalunya, part of Fira Barcelona
- 16:15 Class Session 3 (cont.) - Sports Presentation, speaker to be presented at the time of the session
- 17:30 Bus to Spotify Camp Nou Stadium
- 18:00 Visit Museum Store
- 19:00 Bus departs back to the hotel
- 19:30 Bus arrives at the hotel
- 19:45 Walk to Bar Vint-i Quatre
- 20:30 Presentation by Chef Carles Abellan, top tapas chef and former member of elBulli restaurant, who worked under Chef Ferran Adria (No partners)
- 21:00 Tapas Dinner Experience - an interactive tapas dinner with chef Carles Abellan, as he prepares and presents a selection of tapas in an open kitchen, observing his culinary techniques and creative process firsthand.
- 23:30 Return to the hotel

## **Tuesday, September 15<sup>th</sup>**

- 07:00 Restaurant is open for breakfast (included)
- 09:00 Class Session 4 (at hotel) - Presentation by Mateo Asensio, Former Cruise Area Director, Barcelona Consortium
- Room:** Level A, Crillon-Robert Room*
- 10:30 Coffee break
- 11:00 Bus with luggage departs for Gramona winery (two minibuses)
- 12:00 Arrival at Gramona winery - snack and glass of rosé wine

- 12:30 Visit the cellar
- 13:30 Class Session 5 (at winery) - Presentation by Miquel Herrero, Head of Hospitality and Wine Tourism at the Gramona Winery in Sant Sadurní d'Anoia, Catalonia, Spain
- 14:30 Lunch at the winery
- 16:30 Visit the Gramona vineyards
- 17:45 Bus departs for Barcelona Sants Station
- 18:30 Partners only – transfer booked from hotel to train station
- 19:40 Iryo High Speed Train from Barcelona to Madrid (tickets also secured for partners)
- 22:42 Arrive in Madrid
- 23:00 Bus with bags to hotel - *VP Plaza España Design Hotel, Plaza de España, 5, Centro, 28008 Madrid, Spain*
- 23:30 Hotel check-in. Rooms will be ready; guests need only provide a credit card for incidentals.

### **Wednesday, September 16<sup>th</sup>**

- 07:00 Restaurant is open for breakfast (included)
- 08:15 Meet in lobby for metro (or walk) to Thyssen-Bornemisza National Museum, Paseo del Prado, 8, 28014 Madrid
- 09:15 Class Session 6 (at museum) - Presentation by Ignacio Gutiérrez de Yturriaga, General Manager at the Madrid Conventions Bureau  
  
***Room:** Mirador*
- 10:45 Coffee break
- 11:00 Class Session 6 (cont.) - *Pacha deal* by Javier Garcia-Polencia, CEO Investment Banking and Javier Olascoaga, Senda Investment Partners
- 12:30 Private tour of a collection within the Thyssen-Bornemisza National Museum
- 13:30 Lunch at the museum

- 15:00 Class Session 7 - Presentation by Rocío Trujillo Alba, Regional General Manager-South Europe and Jorge Laso Magro, Institutional Relations Specialist at Fever
- 16:15 Coffee break
- 16:30 Bus departs to Santiago Bernabéu Stadium
- 17:00 Tour of the Stadium with local stadium guides
- 18:30 End of visit

*Free Evening (no transportation from the stadium is booked)*

### **Thursday, September 17<sup>th</sup>**

- 07:00 Restaurant is open for breakfast (included)
- 09:00 Class Session 8 (at hotel) - *Airport economics: the case of Aena* by Julio Garcia Cobos, Founding Partner of PQAXIS consulting and Adjunct Professor at IE Business School
- Room:*** 026,027,028,029
- 10:15 Coffee break
- 10:30 Class Session 8 (cont.) - *Beyond the Pitch: An Entrepreneur's Playbook for Modern Football* by Esteban Granero, Co-Founder of BEST 11 GROUP
- 12:00 Class Session 8 (cont.) - Presentation by Ignacio Aguillo, Founder and CEO of Kaizen Play
- 13:15 Walk to Café de Oriente
- 13:30 Lunch at Café de Oriente
- 15:00 Class Session 9 - Presentation by Felipe Fernández Aramburu, General Manager at Uber
- 16:15 Coffee break
- 16:30 Class Session 9 (cont.) - Wrap-up
- 17:45 Finish wrap-up
- 18:30 Wine-tasting presentation by Eduardo Ferrin, CEO of Alto Winery

- 19:00 Wine-tasting with tapas dinner (Partners are welcome to join)
- 20:30 End of the program and farewell

**Friday, September 18<sup>th</sup>**

- 07:00 Restaurant is open for breakfast (included)

*Travel safely!*